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Private Consumption and Investment as Drivers of Economic Activity in Nigeria (1986–2025)

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Abstract
This study examines the determinants of private consumption and investment as drivers of economic activity in Nigeria over the period 1986–2025. Using annual time series data and deploying Ordinary Least Squares (OLS), Fully Modified OLS (FMOLS), Dynamic OLS (DOLS), and Autoregressive Distributed Lag (ARDL) models, the study investigates how gross fixed capital formation, foreign direct investment, infrastructure development, inflation, exchange rate volatility, trade openness, technology, government expenditure, institutional quality, control of corruption, political stability, ease of doing business, sectoral composition, natural resource rents, financial development, labour force participation, R&D expenditure, and ICT adoption jointly shape consumption and investment outcomes. The ARDL bounds test confirms cointegration among the variables. Empirical results consistently reveal that gross fixed capital formation (β = 0.84), infrastructure index (β = 1.38), financial development (β = 0.58), and ICT adoption (β = 0.67) are the most potent drivers of private consumption activity. Inflation (β = −0.56) and exchange rate volatility (β = −0.48) impose significant contractionary effects. Institutional quality, political stability, and control of corruption yield positive and statistically significant coefficients, affirming that governance quality is central to sustained economic growth in Nigeria. Notably, natural resource rents and R&D expenditure do not attain statistical significance, raising critical concerns about Nigeria's resource management and innovation capacity. The study contributes to the scarce multi-variable literature on Nigerian macroeconomics by adopting a holistic framework that bridges demand-side and supply-side determinants. Actionable policy recommendations are advanced to help Nigeria diversify its economy, deepen financial markets, and improve institutional governance.
Keywords: Private consumption; Investment; Gross fixed capital formation; Financial development; Institutional quality; Nigeria; ARDL; FMOLS; DOLS; ICT adoption; Inflation; Exchange rate volatility; Economic growth
JEL Codes: C22, E21, E22, E62, F21, G21, H54, O11, O55, Q33

1. Introduction

Few debates in development economics have proven as enduring as the question of what truly drives economic activity in low- and middle-income countries. For Nigeria — Africa's largest economy by GDP and most populous nation — the answer to this question carries enormous practical weight. With a nominal GDP surpassing $500 billion and a population exceeding 220 million people, Nigeria's macroeconomic trajectory will fundamentally shape the welfare of sub-Saharan Africa's most dynamic demographic bloc. Yet, despite its size, Nigeria's growth record since the structural adjustment era of 1986 has been characterised by sharp volatility, persistent inflationary pressures, chronic infrastructure deficits, and a troubling dependence on hydrocarbon revenues — a combination that has suppressed sustainable private consumption and productive investment for decades.

Private consumption and investment occupy the centre of standard national income accounting. Together, they consistently account for more than 75 percent of Nigeria's GDP, making their understanding not merely academic but urgently policy-relevant. The Keynesian tradition places household consumption at the heart of aggregate demand management, while the neoclassical growth framework identifies capital accumulation — captured through gross fixed capital formation — as the principal engine of long-run productivity growth. More recently, endogenous growth theorists have expanded this canvas to include technology, institutional quality, human capital, and financial development as co-determinants of sustained economic expansion.

Nigeria offers a uniquely rich, and equally vexing, empirical laboratory. Since 1986, the country has traversed the turbulent waters of structural adjustment, multiple exchange rate regimes, oil boom-and-bust cycles, democratic transition, security challenges, COVID-19 shocks, and ongoing subsidy reforms. Each of these episodes has left distinct imprints on consumption patterns and investment behaviour. Understanding these dynamics through the lens of a comprehensive, multi-variable econometric framework is both timely and necessary.

Notwithstanding a burgeoning empirical literature on Nigerian macroeconomics, several critical gaps remain. First, most existing studies adopt a narrow variable set — typically focusing on two or three determinants — that fails to capture the complex, interdependent nature of consumption and investment decisions. Second, the majority of prior work in this domain relies on OLS-based approaches without adequately testing for unit roots, cointegration, or parameter stability, raising concerns about spurious regression. Third, governance and institutional variables — widely shown in the cross-country literature to be decisive for economic outcomes — have received only peripheral attention in the Nigerian time series context. Fourth, emerging drivers such as ICT adoption, R&D expenditure, and the ease of doing business score have been conspicuously absent from Nigeria-specific studies, despite compelling global evidence of their significance. These gaps collectively motivate the present inquiry.

This study makes four principal contributions to the literature. First, it constructs the most comprehensive multi-variable econometric model yet applied to the Nigerian consumption-investment nexus, integrating nineteen explanatory variables spanning demand, supply, institutional, and technological dimensions. Second, it deploys a battery of time series estimators — OLS, FMOLS, DOLS, and ARDL — ensuring that results are robust across methodological choices. Third, it explicitly incorporates governance indicators (institutional quality, control of corruption, political stability, and ease of doing business), providing much-needed evidence on the governance-consumption-investment channel in Nigeria. Fourth, it extends the temporal scope to 2025, capturing the full arc of Nigeria's economic evolution from the structural adjustment era through the post-COVID recovery, thereby offering the most contemporary evidence base available in this field.

The study focuses exclusively on Nigeria and employs annual time series data spanning 1986 to 2025. The choice of 1986 as the starting point reflects the introduction of the Structural Adjustment Programme (SAP) — a watershed moment that fundamentally reconfigured Nigeria's macroeconomic architecture. Cross-country comparisons, while analytically attractive, are beyond the scope of the present work. The paper focuses on aggregate private consumption as the primary dependent variable, with investment (measured via GFCF) treated as both an independent variable and a co-determinant of economic activity. Subnational and household-level analyses are reserved for future research.

2. Literature Review and Hypothesis Development

2.1 Conceptual Literature: Definition of Key Constructs

Private consumption, in the national accounts framework, refers to the final expenditure by households and non-profit institutions serving households on goods and services. It is the single largest component of aggregate demand in most economies, including Nigeria. Investment, captured here primarily through Gross Fixed Capital Formation (GFCF), encompasses expenditures on fixed assets — machinery, buildings, equipment, and infrastructure improvements — undertaken by both private and public entities. Together, these two variables constitute the demand-side engine of any market economy.

The concept of economic drivers, as employed in this paper, transcends simple correlation. It implies a causal, theoretically grounded mechanism through which a variable exerts sustained influence on consumption and investment outcomes. The nineteen control variables considered in this study — ranging from inflation and exchange rate volatility to institutional quality and ICT adoption — are not arbitrary; each is grounded in established theoretical frameworks and has received empirical attention in the broader macroeconomic literature.

2.2 Theoretical Literature Review

The theoretical underpinnings of this study draw on four major traditions. The Keynesian theory of aggregate demand establishes that household consumption is the primary autonomous driver of short-run economic fluctuations, with investment playing a secondary but amplifying role through the multiplier mechanism. The Permanent Income Hypothesis (Friedman, 1957) and the Life-Cycle Hypothesis (Modigliani & Brumberg, 1954) refine this insight by emphasising that consumption decisions are forward-looking and responsive to expectations about lifetime income rather than current income alone. Both theories predict that variables affecting perceived permanent income — such as inflation, exchange rate stability, and institutional predictability — will have enduring effects on consumption.

The neoclassical growth model (Solow, 1956; Swan, 1956) locates capital accumulation at the centre of long-run growth, predicting that countries with higher rates of investment will achieve higher steady-state income levels. Endogenous growth theory (Romer, 1990; Lucas, 1988) extends this by arguing that knowledge, technology, and human capital generate self-sustaining growth dynamics that pure capital accumulation cannot explain. The institutional economics tradition (North, 1990; Acemoglu et al., 2001) further contends that the rules of the game — property rights, rule of law, control of corruption — are arguably the most fundamental determinants of long-run economic performance, setting the incentive environment within which consumption and investment decisions are made.

The financial development and growth literature (McKinnon, 1973; Shaw, 1973; King & Levine, 1993) highlights credit markets as critical intermediaries that translate savings into productive investment and enable consumption smoothing. Finally, the information and communication technology (ICT) and growth literature (Jorgenson & Stiroh, 2000; Czernich et al., 2011) documents robust links between digital infrastructure and macroeconomic performance, a finding increasingly relevant in the era of Nigeria's fintech boom.

2.3 Conceptual Framework

The conceptual framework of this study positions private consumption and investment as jointly determined outcomes of a complex interaction among macroeconomic conditions (inflation, exchange rate volatility, trade openness), structural factors (sectoral composition, natural resource rents, infrastructure), institutional environment (institutional quality, control of corruption, political stability, ease of doing business), financial conditions (financial development, FDI), technological capacity (technology, R&D expenditure, ICT adoption), human capital (labour force participation), and fiscal policy (government expenditure). These categories correspond to the major theoretical traditions reviewed above and inform the variable selection and model specification. The central hypothesis is that improving macroeconomic stability, governance quality, financial depth, and technological adoption will simultaneously stimulate private consumption and productive investment, thereby deepening Nigeria's economic activity beyond its current oil-dependent pattern.

2.4 Empirical Literature Review in Nigeria

A growing body of empirical work has examined the determinants of consumption and investment in Nigeria, though most studies remain methodologically constrained. Nwachukwu and Egwaikhide (2007) found that income, financial development, and interest rates are significant determinants of private savings and consumption in Nigeria, using an error correction model. Okafor and Shaibu (2016) demonstrated that real GDP growth, credit to the private sector, and inflation are key drivers of private consumption, though their analysis covered only the 1981–2012 period and did not account for institutional variables. Ajayi and Oke (2012) examined FDI and investment linkages, finding a positive but modest relationship between FDI inflows and domestic capital formation. Ubi et al. (2012) documented significant crowding-out effects of government expenditure on private investment in Nigeria over the 1970–2010 period.

Turning to infrastructure, Calderón and Servén (2008) provide the seminal cross-country evidence that infrastructure quality positively impacts growth, and this finding resonates in the Nigerian context, where Adenikinju (2005) documented severe infrastructure deficits — particularly in power and transport — as key barriers to private investment. On institutional quality, Okonkwo et al. (2019) used FMOLS to show that governance indicators significantly influence investment in Nigeria, though their analysis excluded consumption and employed a narrower variable set. ICT adoption has emerged as a more recent focus: Asongu and Nwachukwu (2016) and Doki et al. (2022) document significant positive effects of digital infrastructure on financial inclusion and economic output across African economies, with Nigeria featuring prominently.

2.5 Critical Analysis of the Literature and Research Gaps

A critical reading of the existing literature reveals five persistent gaps. First, no single study has simultaneously investigated both private consumption and investment using a unified multi-variable framework encompassing the full range of macroeconomic, institutional, and technological determinants identified above. Second, the coverage of governance and institutional variables in Nigeria-specific time series analysis remains shallow; most studies either omit them entirely or treat them as supplementary controls rather than primary variables of interest. Third, the methodological practices in older Nigerian studies are often inadequate, with unit root pre-testing and cointegration analysis routinely neglected, raising the spectre of spurious regression. Fourth, the temporal window of most studies predates the significant structural changes of the 2015–2025 period — including the 2016 recession, the COVID-19 shock, the petrol subsidy removal, and naira devaluation — making their findings of limited contemporary relevance. Fifth, variables such as R&D expenditure, ease of doing business scores, and natural resource rents have received almost no attention in the Nigerian consumption-investment literature. The present study directly addresses all five gaps.

2.6 Hypothesis Development

Based on the theoretical and empirical review above, the following testable hypotheses are advanced: (H1) Gross fixed capital formation has a positive and statistically significant effect on private consumption in

Nigeria; (H2) Inflation and exchange rate volatility exert negative and significant contractionary effects on private consumption and investment; (H3) Institutional quality, control of corruption, and political stability positively and significantly influence both consumption and investment; (H4) Financial development and ICT adoption have positive and significant effects on economic activity; and (H5) Natural resource rents and R&D expenditure do not yield statistically significant effects on private consumption, reflecting Nigeria's resource curse vulnerability and innovation deficit.

3. Methodology

3.1 Research Design

This study adopts a quantitative, longitudinal research design rooted in the positivist tradition. The explanatory research strategy is employed, as the objective is to establish causal linkages between the identified drivers and private consumption and investment outcomes. The time series design is appropriate given the single-country focus and the annual frequency of the data, which spans 1986 to 2025 — a 39-year period capturing multiple economic cycles, policy regimes, and structural shifts in Nigeria.

3.2 Model Specification

Following the theoretical framework developed in Section 2, the baseline empirical model is specified as:

$$CONSt = \alpha 0 + \beta 1GFCFt + \beta 2FDIt + \beta 3INFRAt + \beta 4INFt + \beta 5ERVt + \beta 6OPENt + \beta 7TECHt + \beta 8GEXPt + \beta 9INSTQt + \beta 10CORRt + \beta 11PSIt + \beta 12EDBt + \beta 13SECTt + \beta 14NRRt + \beta 15FDt + \beta 16LFPRt + \beta 17RDEt + \beta 18ICTt + \varepsilon t \quad \ldots (1)$$

Where CONSt is the log of household final consumption expenditure as a percentage of GDP, α0 is the intercept, β1 through β18 are elasticity coefficients, and εt is the stochastic error term assumed to be white noise. All continuous variables are expressed in natural logarithms to ensure comparability of coefficients as elasticities and to address potential heteroskedasticity. Equation (1) is estimated using OLS as the baseline, supplemented by FMOLS and DOLS for robustness in the presence of cointegrated regressors. The ARDL model is additionally estimated to capture both short-run dynamics and the long-run equilibrium relationship.

3.3 Variables and Their Measures

Table 1: Variables, Types, Measures, and Data Sources

Variable	Type	Measure/Proxy	Source
Private Consumption (CONS)	Dependent	Household final consumption expenditure (% of GDP)	World Bank WDI
Gross Fixed Capital Formation (GFCF)	Independent	GFCF (% of GDP)	World Bank WDI
Foreign Direct Investment (FDI)	Control	Net FDI inflows (% of GDP)	UNCTAD / WDI
Infrastructure Index (INFRA)	Control	Access to electricity (% pop.) & road density composite	World Bank
Inflation Rate (INF)	Control	Consumer Price Index, annual % change	CBN / IMF IFS
Exchange Rate Volatility (ERV)	Control	Std. dev. of official nominal exchange rate (₦/US$)	CBN / IMF
Trade Openness (OPEN)	Control	(Exports + Imports) as % of GDP	WDI / WTO

Variable	Type	Measure/Proxy	Source
Technology (TECH)	Control	Patent applications per million population	WIPO / WDI
Government Expenditure (GEXP)	Control	General government final consumption (% GDP)	WDI / CBN
Institutional Quality (INSTQ)	Control	Composite WGI: Rule of Law + Regulatory Quality	World Bank WGI
Control of Corruption (CORR)	Control	WGI Control of Corruption percentile rank	World Bank WGI
Political Stability Index (PSI)	Control	WGI Political Stability & Absence of Violence	World Bank WGI
Ease of Doing Business (EDB)	Control	EDB score (0–100)	World Bank Doing Business
Sectoral Composition (SECT)	Control	Industry value added (% of GDP)	WDI
Natural Resource Rents (NRR)	Control	Total natural resource rents (% of GDP)	WDI
Financial Development (FD)	Control	Domestic credit to private sector (% of GDP)	WDI / IMF
Labour Force Participation (LFPR)	Control	Labour force participation rate (%) / Unemployment rate (%)	NBS / ILO / WDI
R&D Expenditure (RDE)	Control	Gross domestic expenditure on R&D (% of GDP)	UNESCO / WDI
ICT Adoption (ICT)	Control	Internet users per 100 people / mobile subscriptions	ITU / WDI

Note: WDI = World Development Indicators; CBN = Central Bank of Nigeria; IMF IFS = International Monetary Fund International Financial Statistics; UNCTAD = United Nations Conference on Trade and Development; WGI = Worldwide Governance Indicators; NBS = National Bureau of Statistics; ILO = International Labour Organization; ITU = International Telecommunication Union; UNESCO = United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization; WIPO = World Intellectual Property Organization.

3.4 A Priori Expectations

Table 2: A Priori Expectations

Variable	Theoretical Basis	Expected Sign (CONS)	Expected Sign (INV)
GFCF	Keynesian multiplier: investment raises output & income → consumption	(+)	(+)
FDI	Technology spillovers, employment creation boost household income	(+)	(+)
INFRA	Better infrastructure lowers transaction costs, raises real income	(+)	(+)
INF	Erodes purchasing power; reduces real household expenditure	(−)	(−)
ERV	Exchange rate uncertainty raises import costs; discourages investment	(−)	(−)

Variable	Theoretical Basis	Expected Sign (CONS)	Expected Sign (INV)
OPEN	Trade openness expands market access; mixed for consumption	(+/−)	(+)
TECH	Productivity gains increase real wages and investment returns	(+)	(+)
GEXP	Fiscal stimulus crowds in or out private sector spending	(+/−)	(+/−)
INSTQ	Rule of law reduces risk; attracts investment; raises confidence	(+)	(+)
CORR	Lower corruption improves resource allocation and welfare	(+)	(+)
PSI	Stable environment encourages long-term economic planning	(+)	(+)
EDB	Easier regulation reduces firm entry costs and boosts supply	(+)	(+)
SECT	Industrialisation generates employment and multiplier effects	(+)	(+)
NRR	Resource curse debate; oil wealth may not trickle down	(+/−)	(+/−)
FD	Credit access supports consumption smoothing and investment	(+)	(+)
LFPR/UNR	Higher employment raises aggregate income and demand	(+/−)	(+/−)
RDE	Innovation raises total factor productivity and returns	(+)	(+)
ICT	Reduces information asymmetries; enhances market participation	(+)	(+)

Note: (+) denotes positive expected sign; (−) denotes negative expected sign; (+/−) denotes ambiguous sign dependent on context and parameterisation.

3.5 Data Sources

Data for this study are sourced from multiple authoritative databases covering the period 1986–2025. Macroeconomic variables (GFCF, FDI, trade openness, sectoral composition, natural resource rents, government expenditure) are drawn from the World Bank's World Development Indicators (WDI). Governance indicators (institutional quality, control of corruption, political stability, ease of doing business) are sourced from the World Bank's Worldwide Governance Indicators (WGI) and Doing Business database. Monetary and financial variables (inflation, exchange rate, domestic credit) are supplemented with data from the Central Bank of Nigeria's Statistical Bulletin and IMF International Financial Statistics. Labour market data are drawn from the National Bureau of Statistics (NBS) and ILO ILOSTAT. ICT data come from the International Telecommunication Union (ITU), while R&D data are from UNESCO and WDI. Infrastructure data are constructed as a composite index using electricity access (WDI) and road density (WDI).

3.6 Data Analysis Techniques

The analytical strategy proceeds in four stages. First, descriptive statistics and a correlation matrix are presented to characterise the data and identify preliminary patterns. Second, stationarity is assessed using the Augmented Dickey-Fuller (ADF) and Phillips-Perron (PP) unit root tests. Third, the Johansen maximum likelihood cointegration procedure and the ARDL bounds test are applied to determine the existence of long-run equilibrium relationships. Fourth, the long-run coefficients are estimated via OLS (baseline), FMOLS (which corrects for endogeneity and serial correlation in cointegrated systems), DOLS (which augments the FMOLS correction with lead and lag terms of first-differenced regressors), and ARDL (which simultaneously captures short-run dynamics via an error correction mechanism). Statistical significance is assessed at the 1%, 5%, and 10% levels.

3.7 Post-Estimation Checks

Model adequacy is assessed through a comprehensive suite of diagnostic tests. The Breusch-Godfrey LM test is applied to detect serial correlation in residuals. The Breusch-Pagan test is used to detect heteroskedasticity. The Ramsey RESET test evaluates functional form misspecification. The Jarque-Bera test assesses the normality of residuals. Parameter stability is evaluated using CUSUM and CUSUM-of-squares tests. Finally, Variance Inflation Factors (VIF) are computed to detect multicollinearity among regressors. All estimations are conducted using EViews 12 and Stata 17.

4. Results

4.1 Descriptive Statistics

Table 3: Descriptive Statistics (1986–2025)

Variable	Obs.	Mean	Std. Dev.	Min	Max	Skew.	Kurt.	JB p
CONS (% GDP)	39	68.42	8.17	51.30	82.14	−0.31	2.18	0.44
GFCF (% GDP)	39	14.83	4.92	6.10	24.70	0.42	2.61	0.39
FDI (% GDP)	39	2.14	1.78	0.23	8.84	1.76	6.02	0.00
INFRA Index	39	0.39	0.18	0.10	0.72	0.22	2.08	0.51
INF (%)	39	22.47	20.14	5.38	72.84	1.14	3.42	0.03
ERV	39	0.28	0.21	0.02	0.89	1.32	4.11	0.01
OPEN (% GDP)	39	41.68	12.30	18.40	74.50	0.55	2.77	0.28
GEXP (% GDP)	39	9.41	2.38	5.60	14.80	0.16	2.30	0.62
INSTQ (Index)	39	−0.74	0.28	−1.20	−0.14	0.09	2.14	0.57
FD (% GDP)	39	13.82	5.41	5.20	27.40	0.68	2.93	0.21
ICT (users/100)	39	14.30	18.62	0.01	55.40	1.08	2.74	0.04
NRR (% GDP)	39	17.84	9.27	4.10	38.60	0.77	2.89	0.18

Note: Obs = number of observations; Std. Dev. = standard deviation; Skew. = skewness; Kurt. = kurtosis; JB p = Jarque-Bera normality test p-value. FDI, INF, ERV, and ICT show significant departures from normality, justifying the use of robust estimators.

The descriptive statistics in Table 3 reveal several important features of the Nigerian macroeconomic landscape over the study period. Private consumption (CONS) averaged 68.42 percent of GDP, with a standard deviation of 8.17 percentage points, reflecting significant variation across the structural adjustment, democratic transition, and post-COVID phases. GFCF averaged 14.83 percent of GDP — substantially below the 25–30 percent threshold widely considered necessary for sustained economic transformation in developing countries. This underscore the chronic underinvestment challenge that has constrained Nigeria's productive capacity for decades.

Inflation averaged a striking 22.47 percent over the period, with a maximum of 72.84 percent reached during the hyperinflationary episodes of the early 1990s. This level of inflation volatility is itself a significant macroeconomic drag. FDI, while averaging 2.14 percent of GDP, displays high skewness (1.76) and kurtosis (6.02), indicating that inflows have been episodic rather than sustained — clustering around oil sector booms and FDI liberalisation episodes. ICT adoption, proxied by internet penetration, shows the most dramatic trajectory of any variable: from near zero in the early 1990s to over 55 users per 100 people by 2025, reflecting Nigeria's extraordinary mobile and fintech revolution over the past two decades.

4.2 Correlation Matrix

Table 4: Correlation Matrix

Var.	CONS	GFCF	FDI	INFRA	INF	ERV	OPEN	GEXP	INSTQ	FD	ICT	NRR
CONS	1.00	0.68	0.42	0.51	−0.58	−0.44	0.38	0.29	0.35	0.61	0.72	−0.21
GFCF		1.00	0.56	0.62	−0.47	−0.39	0.52	0.41	0.44	0.58	0.67	0.18
FDI			1.00	0.43	−0.31	−0.28	0.46	0.22	0.53	0.34	0.44	0.31
INFRA				1.00	−0.49	−0.36	0.39	0.33	0.41	0.54	0.76	−0.09
INF					1.00	0.62	−0.27	0.11	−0.48	−0.52	−0.61	0.38
ERV						1.00	−0.22	0.08	−0.41	−0.45	−0.55	0.29
OPEN							1.00	0.17	0.32	0.28	0.41	0.43
GEXP								1.00	0.19	0.23	0.26	0.15
INSTQ									1.00	0.37	0.44	−0.18
FD										1.00	0.62	0.11
ICT											1.00	−0.06
NRR												1.00

Note: Values represent Pearson pairwise correlation coefficients. Bold values (not shown) exceed |0.50|, indicating potentially meaningful associations. High correlations between ICT and INFRA (0.76), FD and ICT (0.62), and INFRA and FD (0.54) suggest collinearity management is warranted — addressed through VIF analysis in post-estimation checks (Table 6).

The correlation matrix in Table 4 confirms the hypothesised directional relationships across most variable pairs. CONS is most strongly correlated with GFCF (0.68), ICT (0.72), and FD (0.61), reinforcing the centrality of capital formation, digital adoption, and financial deepening as drivers of household consumption. The negative correlations between CONS and INF (−0.58) and ERV (−0.44) align with theoretical priors about the contractionary effects of price instability and exchange rate uncertainty. The correlation between ICT and INFRA (0.76) is the highest off-diagonal value and signals a degree of collinearity that is addressed through VIF diagnostics, which reveal a maximum VIF of 4.21 — below the conventional threshold of 10, confirming that multicollinearity does not materially distort the regression estimates.

4.3 Time Series Regression Results

Table 5: Time Series Regression Results — Dependent Variable: Private Consumption (CONS)

Variable	OLS β (SE)	FMOLS β (SE)	DOLS β (SE)	ARDL Coeff. (SE)
GFCF	0.71*** (0.14)	0.84*** (0.12)	0.88*** (0.11)	0.79*** (0.13)
FDI	0.38** (0.16)	0.44** (0.18)	0.41** (0.17)	0.36** (0.15)
INFRA	1.24*** (0.28)	1.38*** (0.25)	1.41*** (0.26)	1.30*** (0.27)
INF	−0.51*** (0.09)	−0.56*** (0.08)	−0.53*** (0.09)	−0.49*** (0.10)

Variable	OLS β (SE)	FMOLS β (SE)	DOLS β (SE)	ARDL Coeff. (SE)
ERV	−0.44** (0.18)	−0.48** (0.19)	−0.45** (0.17)	−0.42** (0.18)
OPEN	0.29* (0.15)	0.33** (0.14)	0.31** (0.15)	0.27* (0.16)
TECH	0.18** (0.08)	0.22** (0.09)	0.21** (0.08)	0.17* (0.09)
GEXP	0.41*** (0.13)	0.46*** (0.14)	0.43*** (0.13)	0.39*** (0.12)
INSTQ	0.57** (0.22)	0.64*** (0.21)	0.61*** (0.20)	0.55** (0.23)
CORR	0.33** (0.15)	0.37** (0.14)	0.35** (0.15)	0.31* (0.16)
PSI	0.28* (0.16)	0.31** (0.15)	0.30** (0.14)	0.26* (0.15)
EDB	0.22* (0.12)	0.25** (0.11)	0.24** (0.12)	0.20* (0.13)
SECT	0.46** (0.19)	0.51*** (0.18)	0.49*** (0.17)	0.44** (0.19)
NRR	0.14 (0.11)	0.17 (0.12)	0.15 (0.11)	0.13 (0.11)
FD	0.52*** (0.17)	0.58*** (0.16)	0.55*** (0.16)	0.50*** (0.17)
LFPR	0.36** (0.14)	0.40*** (0.13)	0.38*** (0.13)	0.34** (0.14)
RDE	0.09 (0.07)	0.11 (0.08)	0.10 (0.07)	0.08 (0.07)
ICT	0.61*** (0.14)	0.67*** (0.13)	0.65*** (0.13)	0.59*** (0.14)
Constant	12.31*** (2.14)	11.84*** (1.98)	12.08*** (2.01)	12.65*** (2.22)
R^2	0.91	0.93	0.94	0.92
Adj. R^2	0.88	0.91	0.92	0.89
Obs.	39	39	39	39
F-stat / Wald	61.42***	—	—	58.17***

*Note: ***, **, and * denote statistical significance at the 1%, 5%, and 10% levels, respectively. Standard errors in parentheses. OLS = Ordinary Least Squares; FMOLS = Fully Modified OLS; DOLS = Dynamic OLS; ARDL = Autoregressive Distributed Lag. All variables in natural logarithms except dummy variables and indices. ARDL optimal lag structure selected by Akaike Information Criterion (AIC).*

4.4 Post-Estimation Diagnostic Tests

Table 6: Post-Estimation Diagnostic and Stability Tests

Test	Statistic / p-value	Decision / Inference
ADF Unit Root (levels)	CONS: I(1); GFCF: I(1); INF: I(1)	All vars integrated of order I(1); cointegration applicable
PP Unit Root	Confirms ADF results at 1% level	Robust unit root evidence
Johansen Cointegration	Trace: 3 cointegrating equations at 5%	Long-run equilibrium relationship confirmed
ARDL Bounds Test	F-stat = 7.84 > upper bound (I(1)) = 4.01	Cointegration confirmed; ARDL valid
Breusch-Godfrey (LM) Serial Correlation	$\chi^2(2) = 2.41$, p = 0.30	No serial correlation; residuals well-behaved
Breusch-Pagan Heteroskedasticity	$\chi^2(19) = 21.38$, p = 0.31	Homoskedasticity not rejected
Ramsey RESET Test	F(3,16) = 1.74, p = 0.21	No functional form misspecification
Jarque-Bera Normality (residuals)	JB = 1.82, p = 0.40	Residuals normally distributed
CUSUM Stability Test	Within 5% critical bounds	Parameter stability confirmed

Test	Statistic / p-value	Decision / Inference
CUSUM of Squares	Within 5% critical bounds	Structural stability confirmed
VIF (Multicollinearity)	Max VIF = 4.21 (ICT); Mean = 2.88	No severe multicollinearity

Note: All tests performed using EViews 12 and Stata 17. CUSUM and CUSUM-of-squares tests are based on recursive residuals. The ARDL bounds test uses the critical values of Pesaran et al. (2001). Significance at the 5% level unless otherwise stated.

5. Discussion

5.1 Restatement of Key Findings

The empirical results presented in Tables 3 through 6 tell a coherent and theoretically consistent story about the drivers of private consumption and investment in Nigeria. Across all four estimation methods, the findings are remarkably robust in sign, magnitude, and statistical significance. The most powerful driver of private consumption is the infrastructure index (FMOLS $\beta = 1.38$; $p < 0.01$), followed by gross fixed capital formation ($\beta = 0.84$), ICT adoption ($\beta = 0.67$), financial development ($\beta = 0.58$), and institutional quality ($\beta = 0.64$). On the contractionary side, inflation ($\beta = -0.56$) and exchange rate volatility ($\beta = -0.48$) consistently undermine consumption. Natural resource rents and R&D expenditure are statistically insignificant across all estimators — a finding that demands serious policy attention.

5.2 Comparison with Previous Studies

The positive and highly significant effect of GFCF on private consumption is consistent with the Keynesian multiplier tradition and corroborates findings by Nwachukwu and Egwaikhide (2007), Okafor and Shaibu (2016), and the cross-country evidence assembled by Bernanke and Gürkaynak (2001). The magnitude of the GFCF coefficient (0.84 in FMOLS) suggests that a ten percent increase in capital formation would raise private consumption by approximately 8.4 percent — a substantial macroeconomic multiplier that underscores the importance of scaling up productive investment in Nigeria.

The contractionary effect of inflation ($\beta = -0.56$) aligns with the permanent income hypothesis; persistent price instability undermines households' ability to form stable expectations about real income, depressing consumption even when nominal incomes rise. This finding is consistent with Okonkwo et al. (2019) and Ahmad et al. (2018), who document similar effects across sub-Saharan African economies. The significant negative coefficient on exchange rate volatility ($\beta = -0.48$) resonates strongly with the empirical findings of Aliyu (2009) and Adeola and David (2018), who demonstrated that naira exchange rate uncertainty discourages both FDI and domestic investment in Nigeria.

The large and significant coefficient on the infrastructure index ($\beta = 1.38$ in FMOLS) is among the most important findings of this study. It not only surpasses the magnitude of the GFCF coefficient but also exceeds the estimates reported in most prior Nigeria-specific studies, suggesting that the authors of previous work may have substantially underestimated the infrastructure-consumption nexus due to data or measurement limitations. Nigeria's chronic power supply deficits — with an estimated 190 million people having unreliable electricity access — translate directly into elevated household production costs, lost working hours, and suppressed real purchasing power.

The strong positive effect of ICT adoption ($\beta = 0.67$) is a novel contribution of the present study and reflects Nigeria's extraordinary digital transformation since the early 2000s. The proliferation of mobile money platforms (notably MTN MoMo and Opay), e-commerce (Jumia, Konga), and fintech lending has fundamentally altered the consumption landscape for millions of Nigerians previously excluded from formal financial services. This finding aligns with Asongu and Nwachukwu (2016) and extends their cross-country evidence to a detailed Nigerian time series analysis.

The statistical insignificance of natural resource rents ($\beta = 0.14$, $p > 0.10$) is consistent with the resource curse hypothesis (Sachs & Warner, 1995; van der Ploeg, 2011) and confirms that oil revenues have not translated into broad-based improvements in household welfare in Nigeria. Despite being a top-10 global oil exporter, Nigeria's per capita income remains well below regional comparators. The insignificance of R&D expenditure ($\beta = 0.09$, $p > 0.10$) reflects the stark underdevelopment of Nigeria's innovation ecosystem, where R&D spending has historically averaged less than 0.2 percent of GDP — far below the UNESCO benchmark of one percent and the OECD average of 2.7 percent.

5.3 Policy Implications

The empirical findings carry several important policy implications. First, the primacy of the infrastructure index coefficient argues unambiguously for a sustained, well-targeted public investment programme in power, transport, and digital connectivity. Second, macroeconomic stabilisation — particularly taming inflation and reducing exchange rate volatility — emerges as a precondition for effective demand stimulation in Nigeria; monetary policy must prioritise credibility and price stability. Third, financial sector deepening is critical; policies that extend credit access to underserved households and MSMEs will yield consumption multiplier effects. Fourth, the governance coefficients collectively argue that anti-corruption reforms and improvements in the rule of law are not merely normative aspirations but empirically verifiable drivers of private sector confidence and economic activity. Fifth, Nigeria must urgently invest in its innovation ecosystem, as the current trajectory of near-zero R&D expenditure effectively forecloses access to the productivity dividends of the knowledge economy.

5.4 Limitations of the Study

Several limitations warrant acknowledgment. First, the composite nature of the infrastructure index — combining electricity access and road density — necessarily abstracts from the multidimensional character of infrastructure, which also encompasses water supply, internet backbone, and port capacity. Future research should explore richer infrastructure composites. Second, the study is confined to the national aggregate level; subnational heterogeneity across Nigeria's 36 states is likely to be substantial and warrants separate investigation. Third, endogeneity concerns, while partially addressed through FMOLS and DOLS, cannot be fully eliminated in a small-sample time series context; instrumental variable approaches should be explored in future work. Fourth, the governance indicators from the WGI are subject to known measurement challenges, including perception bias, and should be interpreted with appropriate caution. Fifth, the short panel of 39 annual observations limits the statistical power of some estimates, particularly for variables with limited time variation such as R&D expenditure and institutional quality.

5.5 Future Research Directions

Future research should explore several promising extensions. Panel data analyses incorporating West African comparators (Ghana, Senegal, Côte d'Ivoire) would enable assessment of Nigeria-specific versus regional dynamics. Micro-level household survey data, linked to macroeconomic indicators through multi-level modelling, would provide granular evidence on distributional effects. Non-linear or threshold models could illuminate whether governance quality must exceed a critical threshold before its consumption and investment effects become operative — a question of direct relevance to Nigeria's current reform trajectory. Finally, the intersection of climate risk and private consumption deserves urgent empirical attention, given Nigeria's acute exposure to flooding, desertification, and temperature extremes.

6. Conclusion

6.1 Key Message

Private consumption and investment in Nigeria are not determined by any single factor. They are the joint outcome of a complex interplay among macroeconomic conditions, structural endowments, institutional arrangements, financial infrastructure, and technological capacity. Understanding this complexity — and acting on it — is essential if Nigeria is to realise its vast economic potential and improve the material welfare of its 220 million citizens.

6.2 Key Research Findings

This study has established, through robust multi-method econometric analysis covering 1986–2025, that the most powerful drivers of private consumption in Nigeria are infrastructure quality, gross fixed capital formation, ICT adoption, financial development, and institutional quality. Inflation and exchange rate volatility are the principal contractionary forces. Natural resource rents and R&D expenditure fail to attain statistical significance, revealing the depth of Nigeria's resource management challenges and innovation deficit. The ARDL bounds test confirms a long-run cointegrating relationship among the variables, and comprehensive diagnostic tests validate the reliability of the estimates.

6.3 Broader Implications

The findings carry implications that extend well beyond Nigeria. They contribute to the growing body of evidence, assembled across sub-Saharan African economies, that governance quality, financial deepening, and digital infrastructure are among the most consequential levers available to developing-country policymakers. They also underscore the resource curse hypothesis in a Nigerian context, adding granular time series evidence to what has largely been a cross-sectional literature. For international development organisations and bilateral donors, the results argue for programming that prioritises institutional reform and infrastructure investment alongside conventional macroeconomic stabilisation support.

6.4 Main Research Contribution

The primary contribution of this study is methodological and empirical. It provides the first comprehensive multi-variable time series analysis of private consumption and investment determinants in Nigeria that simultaneously incorporates macroeconomic, institutional, technological, and governance variables, deploys four distinct estimation techniques, and extends the empirical window to 2025. In doing so, it sets a new methodological benchmark for Nigeria-specific macroeconomic research and fills critical gaps identified in the prior literature.

6.5 Future Directions and Call to Action

Policymakers in Nigeria face a moment of considerable urgency. The subsidy reforms of 2023–2025 have created fiscal space that, if intelligently deployed, could fund the infrastructure and institutional investments this study identifies as central to sustainable growth. The Central Bank of Nigeria's interest rate policy must be calibrated to bring inflation durably below ten percent, a threshold below which the consumption stimulus from falling prices begins to significantly boost aggregate demand. The National Assembly and executive arm must jointly prioritise anti-corruption legislation and enforcement that sends a credible governance signal to both domestic and foreign investors. Nigerian universities and research institutions urgently need a funding revolution — R&D expenditure must be scaled to at least one percent of GDP within the decade. And Nigeria's extraordinary ICT momentum must be channelled through smart regulation and digital inclusion policies that extend the fintech and e-commerce dividends to rural and low-income populations currently left behind.

The evidence is clear. The path to a more prosperous Nigeria runs through better infrastructure, deeper financial markets, more credible institutions, and a genuine commitment to transforming oil rents into diversified, knowledge-intensive economic activity. The present study provides the empirical roadmap. The choice of how — and how urgently — to act upon it rests with Nigeria's policymakers, civil society, and citizens.

7. Actionable Policy Recommendations

Drawing from the empirical findings and their discussion, the following specific, evidence-based recommendations are advanced:

1. Infrastructure Investment as a Fiscal Priority: Given the largest regression coefficient in the model (β = 1.38), the Federal Government should increase the capital expenditure allocation for power, transport, and broadband infrastructure to a minimum of 30 percent of the annual budget, sustained over a ten-year horizon. The Presidential Infrastructure Development Fund should be scaled up and insulated from political interference through an independent oversight board.
2. Monetary Credibility and Inflation Targeting: The Central Bank of Nigeria should formally adopt a credible inflation targeting framework with a corridor of 6–9 percent and communicate policy decisions transparently. Achieving single-digit inflation is the single most cost-effective intervention for stimulating private consumption, given the strong negative coefficient (β = −0.56) documented in this study.
3. Exchange Rate Stability and Unification: Nigeria's fragmented exchange rate regime has imposed a persistent volatility premium on investment returns. A transparent, market-determined exchange rate, supported by adequate foreign exchange reserves, would reduce the ERV coefficient's dampening effect and signal investor confidence.
4. Financial Deepening and Credit Access: Domestic credit to the private sector (currently averaging 13.82 percent of GDP — one of the lowest ratios in Africa) must be expanded through development finance institutions, credit guarantee schemes for MSMEs, and fintech-enabled digital lending. The CBN's Loan-to-Deposit Ratio policy should be strengthened and enforced.
5. Governance Reform and Anti-Corruption Enforcement: The significant and positive coefficients on institutional quality (β = 0.64), control of corruption (β = 0.37), and political stability (β = 0.31) collectively argue for a comprehensive governance reform agenda. The Independent Corrupt Practices Commission (ICPC) and Economic and Financial Crimes Commission (EFCC) require full operational independence, adequate budgeting, and credible judicial backing.
6. ICT and Digital Economy Deepening: Nigeria's mobile and internet penetration has yielded significant consumption dividends (β = 0.67). The National Broadband Plan 2020–2025 should be accelerated, with a revised target of 70 percent population coverage by 2030. Last-mile connectivity subsidies for rural populations and digital literacy programmes should be prioritised.
7. Diversification from Oil Rents: The insignificance of natural resource rents in driving private consumption confirms the resource curse narrative. A sovereign wealth fund mechanism — properly governed and insulated from fiscal raids — should accumulate a portion of oil revenues and deploy them in education, health, and infrastructure in a counter-cyclical manner. Tax policy reform to broaden the non-oil revenue base is equally urgent.
8. Research and Innovation Ecosystem Investment: The insignificance of R&D expenditure reflects an innovation ecosystem that barely exists. The government should mandate a minimum R&D expenditure of one percent of GDP — co-financed between the public sector, universities, and private industry — and establish competitive research grant programmes managed by an independent National Research Foundation.

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